

Human Centered Design Track: Assignment 1- Research Foundation Paper

Working Group 6-Language Barriers Preventing Refugees From Accessing Services

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Research Topic

Investigating how language barriers affect refugees' access to health and legal protection in rural settlements of Uganda

Background

Uganda Refugee Context

Uganda is one of Africa's largest refugee-hosting countries, with a long history of receiving displaced populations from neighbouring states. It operates a progressive open-door policy that grants refugees freedom of movement, the right to work, and access to social services such as healthcare and education (Komakech et al., 2025). Most refugees originate from South Sudan, the Democratic Republic of Congo, and other regional conflicts, and reside in government-designated settlements, particularly in the West Nile region (Komakech et al., 2025, p. 2). Despite inclusive policies, access to services remains challenged by infrastructure constraints and limited resources (Komakech et al., 2025).

Language barriers in health and law protection services

Refugees and asylum seekers often encounter language barriers when accessing health and legal protection services in host countries, limiting their ability to communicate needs, understand information, and exercise their rights effectively (UNHCR, 2024; Mukungu & Ngulube, 2026). Language differences can reduce the quality and effectiveness of healthcare interactions, contributing to misunderstandings, delayed treatment, and unequal access to essential services and support (UNHCR, 2024; Mukungu & Ngulube, 2026). In legal and protection contexts, effective communication is necessary for accessing justice, obtaining documentation, and understanding rights and procedures (UNHCR, 2024; Mukungu & Ngulube, 2026). These challenges can undermine the protection, safety, and overall well-being of refugee populations (UNHCR, 2024; Mukungu & Ngulube, 2026).

Problem Statement

According to UNHCR reports towards 2024, Uganda has experienced a tremendous surge in refugee arrivals predominantly from Sudan as a result of the ongoing political unrests and insurgencies. By the end of the year 2024, 65,500+ Sudanese were seeking refuge. As a matter of policy, Uganda granted them 'prima facie' refugee status as of November 2023. The total refugee population was approximated to be 1,800,000. This was a 10% increase from 2023. These refugees were stipulated from the following nationalities; South Sudan - 57%, DRC - 31%, other nations such as Rwanda and Ethiopia shared the remaining percentage. 80% of these refugees were women and children. (UNHCR, 2024).

Health workers, legal aid officers, and other service providers often struggle to communicate effectively with refugees due to cultural and language barriers in service delivery (World Health Organization, 2024). Professional interpreters are often unavailable, expensive, or difficult to access when needed. As a result, refugees may receive incorrect information, experience delays in receiving support, misunderstand important procedures, or face challenges in exercising their rights.

Language barriers also make it difficult for service providers to deliver quality services and respond effectively to refugee needs. This communication gap can negatively affect the protection, wellbeing, and inclusion of refugees. Therefore, there is a need to better understand how language barriers affect both refugees and service providers in Uganda, particularly within health and legal services, and how these barriers impact access to essential support and protection.

Research Questions

1. What communication challenges do refugees and service providers experience due to language barriers during the delivery of health and legal protection services in rural settlements of Uganda?
2. How do language barriers affect refugees' access to health and legal protection services in rural settlements of Uganda?
3. How do language barriers influence the ability of service providers to deliver effective health and legal protection services to refugees in rural settlements of Uganda?
4. How do language barriers affect the mental health of refugees when accessing essential services in host countries?
5. What strategies do refugees and service providers currently use to overcome language barriers during the delivery of health and legal protection services?

Objectives of the Study

This study aims to investigate the effects of language barriers on refugees' access to health and legal protection services in rural communities of Uganda. Specifically, it seeks to:

1. Identify communication challenges experienced by refugees and service providers during health and legal service delivery.
2. Examine how language barriers influence refugees' access to healthcare services.
3. Assess how language barriers affect refugees' access to legal protection services.
4. Explore the perceived potential of AI-assisted translation solutions to improve communication and service delivery.

Relevance of the Study

This study is highly relevant as Uganda's refugee population expands, worsening communication gaps in rural settlements. By pinpointing how language barriers obstruct justice and healthcare, this research provides critical data for the Office of the Prime Minister, UNHCR, and NGOs. Ultimately, it informs evidence-based humanitarian policies and highlights the practical potential of AI-assisted translation tools to improve service delivery and protect vulnerable refugee rights.

Significance of the Study

This study is significant in addressing critical gaps in understanding how language barriers affect refugee service access in sub-Saharan African contexts. While refugee health system integration has been examined in Uganda, limited attention has been given to how communication challenges influence both healthcare and broader service delivery in rural settlements (Komakech et al., 2025). Evidence from similar African contexts shows that language barriers lead to misunderstandings, delays in diagnosis, and reduced quality of care, highlighting the real-life implications of communication breakdowns for both refugees and service providers (Agbor-Ntoh et al., 2024)

This study contributes practically by capturing lived experiences often overlooked in statistical reports and provides evidence to inform more inclusive and linguistically responsive service delivery approaches. The findings are also valuable for policymakers and humanitarian actors seeking to improve service accessibility. Furthermore, by exploring innovative communication solutions, including emerging digital tools, the study opens pathways for improving future humanitarian interventions.

References

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